

WORKSHEET

Pursuing Justice

Torah: Deuteronomy 16:18–21:9 · **Haftarah:** Isaiah 51:12–52:12 · **Gospel:** John 14:9–20

In Shoftim all authority — judge, king, prophet, priest — is given by God, and precisely therefore bounded and testable. Around the image of the king who copies out the Torah by his own hand, ‘that his heart may not be lifted up,’ the reading moves toward a God who protects life even in war, and toward Yeshua as the authority that does ‘not speak from Himself.’

Work from top to bottom: first observe (A1), then weigh (A2), then diagnose (A3), and only then summarize (A4). Observation precedes interpretation, so you do not read into the text what you draw from it moments later. Below is a fully filled-in example for Shoftim; use it as a model, and dare to leave the open questions and anomalies open.

Basic details

→ *First fill in the basics: which passage, which haftarah, any flanking reading with its status, and for whom you are making this.*

Parashah / delimitation: Shoftim — Deuteronomy 16:18–21:9

Haftarah / ritual place: Isaiah 51:12–52:12 (third comfort sabbath; sheva de-nechemta)

Flanking reading and status: John 14:9–20 — New Testament mirroring, confessionally used (not as peshat on the Torah).

Target group and desired form: Study group / congregation · a compact study and a spoken reading.

A1. Text blocks and peshat

→ Read block by block. Note first what it says, then the key word or contrast, and only then a genuine open question — without an answer yet.

Text block	What does it say? (peshat)	Key words / contrast	Open question
16:18–20	Appoint judges in all your gates; no bribe or partiality; ‘justice, justice you shall pursue’.	tzedek tzedek (2×) · pursue · righteous means	Why does ‘justice’ appear twice?
17:8–13	Too-difficult cases go to the high court at the chosen place; the ruling is binding.	high court · binding authority	Why not let each administer his own justice?
17:14–20	The king whom God chooses; no horses/wives/gold; he writes out the Torah and reads for life, ‘that his heart may not be lifted up’.	God chooses · copy of the Torah · heart not lifted up	What does that limit do to the kingship?
18:9–22	No divination (not like the nations); ‘you shall be blameless’; the prophet like Moses, with the test: does his word come true?	tamim/blameless · directed at God vs at self · prophet test	If a sign comes true, is that proof?
19:15–21	Two or three witnesses, not one; careful investigation; the false witness; ‘eye for eye’ as proportionality.	two witnesses · investigation · proportionality	Is ‘eye for eye’ an incitement or a limit?
20:19–20; 21:1–9	Spare the fruit tree in war (‘is the tree a man?’); at an unsolved murder the	limit in war · ‘our hands... have not shed’	Why a limit precisely where

Text block	What does it say? (peshat)	Key words / contrast	Open question
	elders wash their hands over innocent blood.		power is greatest?

A2. Connecting hypotheses

→ *Formulate two readings the text could carry, and choose with the test: which explains the most data with the least force? Also name what could refute your reading.*

Hypothesis 1 (one axis): the center of gravity is the Source axis alone — all authority comes from God (king, prophet, priest). The limits are then merely an outworking of that legitimacy.

Hypothesis 2 (relation): the center of gravity is the relation between Source and Coherence — authority is given, AND precisely therefore bounded, testable, and accountable.

Which explains the most data with the least force? Hypothesis 2.

Hypothesis 1 explains the source, but makes the overwhelming emphasis on limits (king-under-the-Torah, prophet test, witnesses, proportionality, the fruit tree) a side issue — that costs force. Hypothesis 2 explains both, and the text stages the coupling itself: 17:18–20 binds the source (God chooses the king) to the limit (he writes out the Torah), and 18:15–22 binds the prophet’s legitimacy to the test.

What would refute this reading? If 17:18–20 and 18:15–22 turned out not to be structural hinges but loose rules, the relation would be imposed. Honest limit: hypothesis 2 risks a too-neat synthesis; the safeguard is that those verses name source AND limit in one breath.

A3. Four axes

→ *Fill in the text anchors and a short diagnosis per axis. Leave the last column for what your reading does not smooth over — the anomaly that honestly stays open.*

Axis	Text anchors	Diagnosis	Open anomaly
Source	17:15 (king) · 18:15 (prophet) · 18:2 (priest)	Dominant. All authority is given, not arrogated; illegitimate sources are rejected.	Why permit a king at all if it is so risky?
Trajectory	17:14 ('when you come into the land')	Thin. Points forward to the future, instituted order.	Is the self-exalting king past, or a lasting temptation?
Will	16:20 (pursue) · 16:18 (appoint) · 21:6 (wash hands)	Bounded-active: pursue justice, establish offices, carry responsibility.	Where does 'pursue' pass over into 'grasp'?
Coherence	17:20 (heart not lifted) · 18:22 (test) · 19:15,21 (witnesses, proportionality)	Dominant, interlocks with Source. One system of limits on power; authority stays testable.	How do you distinguish 'correctable' from 'open to anything'?

Reactivity: mildly present ('not like the nations', 18:9) but not foregrounded — note it as observation, and do not impose it.

A4. Movement

→ Summarize the movement: what does the text unmask, what frame does it put in its place, what response follows, and capture it in one core sentence.

What is unmasked? Authority that cuts itself loose from the source and makes itself the measure — the king whose heart lifts itself (17:20), the presumptuous prophet (18:20), the false witness (19:18).

What frame does the text put in its place? Authority that is given and therefore lets itself be tested: under the Torah, with witnesses, proportional, accountable — as a brother among brothers.

What concrete response and formation follow? Pursue justice by righteous means; receive your place and stay under it; carry

responsibility, even for blood that does not cling to your hands.

Core sentence: *Pursuing justice: authority that is given, and precisely therefore bounded and accountable.*

Horizon (not this week's theme, but the ground): beneath all this lies the one question — received or grasped. Self-arrogated authority is the grasped form; received, testable authority the received form. This time the text pressed hardest on the Source–Coherence relation.